planned the punishment session so I would be exhausted and fall asleep, instead of staying awake and worrying about the check sortie.

I woke up the next day even before Anuradha's alarm went off. When she came to my cabin, I was already getting ready. 'When you sit inside the cockpit, just imagine you are alone,' she advised. She was equally worried. It was one of those rare occasions that I was seated before time for the mass briefing. But I do not remember listening to any of it that day. I desperately wanted Babs Sir to do something and postpone the sortie. But he seemed confident about me and assured me in the ops room that it would all go well. We went for a half-hour sortie together, in which he made me revise all the basics and aerobatic manoeuvres. When we returned, I could see the CFI already standing at the tarmac in his overalls, with a ready aircraft. As soon as we landed, the CFI took me with him without even letting me talk to Babs Sir. I was so scared I wanted to cry. But it was too late. The solo check sortie had begun. Before I could say anything, I had already taken off.

To clear a solo check, one must show the CFI three consecutive safe landings, apart from a plethora of other checks, since landing is always the most difficult part. It was a bright sunny day and the sky was placidly clear, one of the most perfect days for flying. What wasn't perfect was the man I accompanied in this sortie. His presence alone made me so nervous that I committed some really silly mistakes during the first landing, mistakes I had never committed earlier with Babs Sir. Wing Commander Patil blew his top inside the cockpit.

'What the hell was that? You've come for a solo check, do you realize that? This is what you want to show me?'

Since it was a roller take-off, I opened the throttle again after touch-down, going for a take-off right after landing without stopping, and advanced high into the blue sky. The CFI was shouting so loud I couldn't even hear the engine revving. 'If you repeat this in the next landing, I'll throw you out of the flying branch,' he shouted one last time before he went quiet again. My hands shivered and tears filled my eyes. I had to do something. I could not afford to lose my calm at this moment. I closed my